Emotional Intelligence Foundations - Study guide

Foundation course | Trainer: Maya Thompson

About this guide

Build self-awareness and learn to respond rather than react at work.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Recognise your own emotional patterns

- Use a simple pause routine under pressure

- Read the room in meetings more accurately

Why emotional intelligence matters at work

- A skill, not a personality type

- It shapes how you handle pressure, feedback and conflict

- Anyone can improve it with practice

Emotional intelligence is the ability to notice emotion, understand what it is telling you, and choose a useful response. People often mistake it for being nice, or for staying calm all the time. It is neither of those. It is a set of habits. Because it is a skill and not a personality type, anyone can get better at it. In this lecture we will cover what emotional intelligence is and is not, how to spot your own patterns, a simple routine for pressure, and how to read a room more accurately.

What it is, and what it is not

- It is noticing, understanding and choosing

- It is not suppressing feelings

- It is not the same as being agreeable

Start with what it is not. It is not hiding what you feel, and it is not agreeing with everyone to keep the peace. Someone can be highly emotionally intelligent and still disagree firmly. What matters is that they notice what is going on inside them, understand why, and then decide how to act, instead of being driven by the first

reaction. Think of it as adding a short gap between feeling something and doing something. That gap is where good judgement lives, and it is the gap we will work on throughout this course.

The four parts of emotional intelligence

- Self-awareness: noticing your own emotions

- Self-management: choosing your response

- Social awareness: reading other people

- Relationship skills: acting on what you read

A useful way to organise the skill is in four parts. Self-awareness is noticing your own emotions as they happen. Self-management is choosing how you respond rather than reacting. Social awareness is reading what other people are feeling, from their words and their body language. Relationship skills are using all of that to communicate, give feedback and resolve disagreement. The parts build on each other. If you cannot notice your own frustration, you will struggle to manage it, and you will probably miss the same feeling in the person across the table.

Mapping your triggers

- Triggers follow patterns

- Note the situation, the person and the time of day

- Name the feeling in one word

Most reactive moments are not random. They follow a pattern. A certain kind of email, a certain person interrupting, the end of a long day. The first practical step is to map your triggers. For one week, whenever you feel pulled off balance, write down three things: what happened, who was involved, and the time of day. Then name the feeling in a single word, such as irritated, anxious or dismissed. Naming it matters, because a named feeling is easier to manage than a vague one. After a week, look for repeats.

The ninety second pause

- Breathe

- Name the feeling

- Decide the next useful step

Once you know your triggers, you need something to do in the moment. The ninety second pause is a short, repeatable routine for the gap between a trigger and your response. First, breathe out slowly, longer than you breathe in. Second, name the feeling to yourself in one word. Third, decide the next useful step, which might be answering, asking a question, or saying that you will come back to it. It sounds almost too simple. That is the point. Under pressure you will not remember a complicated method, but you can remember three steps.

Reading the room

- Notice who is speaking and who is quiet

- Watch for changes in tone and pace

- Check your read with a question

Reading the room means noticing the signals other people give off, and adjusting how you contribute so your point lands. In a meeting, notice who is speaking a lot and who has gone quiet. Notice when the pace or tone changes, or when someone looks away. These are signals, not proof. So check your read with a question, such as, it seems like there are some concerns, what are we missing. Asking is better than assuming. Over time, this habit makes you the person who senses a problem early, instead of the one surprised by it.

Putting it together on a normal Tuesday

- Trigger, then pause, then choice

- Practise on small moments first

- Review once a week

Here is how the pieces fit on an ordinary day. A message arrives that annoys you. You notice the tightness, which is self-awareness. You take your ninety second pause, which is self-management. Before you reply, you think about what the sender might be

dealing with, which is social awareness. Then you write a reply that gets the result you want, which is a relationship skill. Practise on small moments first, not the hardest conversation of the year. And once a week, spend ten minutes reviewing which triggers showed up and how you handled them.

Your next steps

- Pick one trigger to work on this week

- Use the pause three times

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, choose one trigger from your map and commit to using the pause the next three times it appears. Do not try to fix everything at once. Open the workbook for this course and complete the exercises, because writing things down makes them stick. Then take the final quiz, which checks the main ideas from every phase. When you finish the last lesson, you will receive your certificate and a short personal review of how you worked through the course. Thank you for listening, and good luck putting this into practice.

Glossary

Emotional intelligence: The ability to notice emotion, understand what it is telling you and choose a useful response.

Trigger: A situation, person or moment that reliably pulls you off balance.

Self-awareness: Noticing your own emotions and reactions as they happen.

Ninety second pause: A three-step routine for the gap between a trigger and your response: breathe, name the feeling, decide the next step.